A Friendly Competition

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by Overdrewmatic_Lesbian

Summary

It's time for the groups annual greeting card competition, an event that Catra has never real cared about. This year, however, she wants nothing more than to win, and she knows just what heartstrings she needs to pull to make it happen.

Part of the SPOP Flex Icebreaker Zine (link included in notes)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Catra's friends have forced her to partake in a lot of "traditions" over the years, the most ridiculous one of all being that of the Solstice Greeting Card Contest.

It had started in college, when Scorpia had sadly noted that no one ever seemed to give out holiday cards anymore, a practice that she greatly missed. Soon, that one comment had turned into an obligation, where everyone made a personalized greeting card to present to the group along with their gifts.Then, following a particularly heated discussion between Glimmer and Mermista on whose card would be better, the practice became a judged event.

Catra knew from the start she'd get grief from the group if she didn't participate, but that didn't mean she had ever put much effort into her submissions. Her earliest entries had been created by uploading the most recent photo of Melog onto one of the local drugstore templates. Then, when it was announced that they could work in pairs, she teamed up with Adora, always letting her now-wife have control over every aspect of the card. Sure, that meant every year she'd end up wearing an extremely tacky sweater as she posed like a lovesick idiot for the camera, but she couldn't really complain. She got to make her wife happy while putting in the minimal amount of effort required; it was a total win-win for everyone.

This year was different though, because she had worked hard to ensure their card would blow everyone else's out of the water.

"Those idiots won't know what hit them," Catra smugly whispered to herself as she walked up Glimmer and Bow's driveway, the day of the holiday party having finally arrived.

Adora nervously laughed next to her, her arms full with all the things they had brought for their friends. "Listen, as much as I love your sudden interest in this, don't you think you might now be taking it a little too seriously?"

Catra playfully smiled in a way that showed off her fangs. “Maybe this has been my master plan all along. Lay low in the beginning, lulling everyone into a false sense of security while I waited for the perfect opportunity to strike.”

An impish grin grew on Adora’s face as they stepped onto the porch. “Your master plan, huh? You mean the one where you pined for me for years-”

“I was never pining!”

“-confessed your love for me; married me; before finally deciding to take the next big step with me and got yourself-”

Before Adora could finish her taunting, the door swung wide open, Glimmer appearing from behind it.

“You’re here! Finally!”

Adora quickly checked the watch on her wrist. “The party only started fifteen minutes ago, Glim.”

“Exactly!” The woman grabbed their wrists and pulled them into the entryway. “You guys are late, meaning we still haven’t opened up the cards.”

“Oh, I see what’s going on,” Catra announced as they approached the living room. “You think your card’s got everyone else’s beat this year.”

“No, I know it’s got everyone else’s beat. I’ve been working on it for the past six months.”

“Impressive,” the Magicat drawled lazily. “Don’t get too comfortable, though. You’re going to have some steep competition from us this year.”

Glimmer let out a snort. “I doubt it’ll be that hard to top whatever tacky Solstice sweaters you guys picked out.” After a moment of silence, she quickly added, “No offense, Adora.”

Catra watched as her wife’s eyes narrowed, a serious expression forming on her face that indicated she had taken offense to her friend's words. All too happy to fan those flames, she whispered, “Are you just gonna let her talk about your sweaters like that?”

“Oh, we’re going to crush her. You’re the only one who's allowed to make fun of my tacky sweaters.”

Once in the living room, the group of friends was quick to embrace the newly arrived couple, eager to make small talk. They were quickly interrupted by Glimmer’s impatience.

“Okay everyone,” she announced loudly. “Everyone remembers the rules of the competition, right? We all open the card for whoever’s turn it is, and once all of them have been revealed, we’ll individually rank them from best to worst on our ballots. Then, the ballots will be put into this box so that Bow can tally up the scores and announce the overall winner at dinner.”

Catra dismissively waved her hand in Glimmer’s direction, now sitting down on the floor across from her. “Yeah, yeah, Sparkles, we know the drill. Just pass out your card already.”

“No way am I going first. The first card literally never wins. You and Adora should go.”

“Wait! If going first is such a death sentence, then no way are we doing it.”

“Scorpia and I will go first,” Perfuma interrupted, trying to keep the peace as usual. “It’s really not that big of a deal.”

After Scorpia had finished passing out the sealed envelopes, everyone was quick to open them up. Inside turned out to be a picture of the happy couple from their wedding day seven months ago.

“It’s beautiful,” Bow commented.

“The flowers we used to border the photo represent mine and Scorpia’s birth months,” Perfuma cheerfully informed.

“On the back we wrote about how much you all mean to us,” Scorpia added. “You guys made our day so special, just by being there.”

Over the next half hour, everyone’s cards got opened. Each one of them somehow meaningfully represented the couple or individual captured in it. Netossa and Spinnerella had used one from their anniversary vacation at the beach. Frosta had kept her tradition of making an ice sculpture, this year’s subject being a wolf. Mermista and Sea Hawk included a photo of them participating in a polar plunge, one where Sea Hawk looked like he was absolutely suffering in the ice cold water while Mermista swam around him nonchalantly. Entrapta’s card had initially appeared to be completely blank, but a photo of her working in her lab appeared after she had instructed everyone to hold it up to the light.

“It’s so cool you were able to do that,” Scorpia commented.

Entrapta beamed at the compliment. “It took me a while to hunt down all of the necessary materials, but that made the process even more fun!”

“You did a great job,” Catra declared.

Then, with a mischievous grin, she turned her attention towards the person sitting across from her. “ It would seem like it’s just me and you left, Sparkles.”

“Um, and me and Adora,” Bow added, his gaze nervously shifting between the two women. “These are our Solstice cards too, remember?”

The two women didn’t even seem to register his words, opting to continue staring each other down.

Adora gulped nervously at the sight. As keen as she was on winning, she did not want a repeat of their last game night, where

Catra and Glimmer's competitiveness had gotten extremely out of hand. She was still trying to get that stain out of her couch from when they'd started tossing drinks at each other.

Trying to move the process along, she gestured to Bow in a way that silently asked if he wanted her and Catra to go first.

Bow shook his head and reached for the stack of cards beside him. Just like Adora knew her wife, he knew his. She'd be a lot less critical of whatever her friends had done if she got to show off her hard work beforehand.

"The wax seal is a really nice touch," Spinnerella commented as she was handed one of the envelopes.

"I like the shade of purple you used," Entrapta added.

"You know what they say," Glimmer replied with a satisfied smile. "Presentation is everything."

As much as Catra loved to goad Glimmer into petty competitions, the woman was one of her closest friends, and she did have an eye for design. So the Magicat couldn't really stop herself from smiling when she opened up the envelope and was presented with the other's card.

The couple seemed to have decided to go with some sort of fantasy theme this year, Bow dressed as a medieval archer and Glimmer as a fairy princess. The photo had clearly been taken in the nearby forest, the wildflowers that grew there creating a breathtaking backdrop. The couple's love for each other was evident in the way their bodies wrapped around each other, their foreheads touching as they smiled. On the bottom of the card, the words, 'have a magical holiday season,' were written in fancy cursive.

"That's so pretty," Adora said, leaning over her wife's shoulder to get a better look. "You two really outdid yourselves."

The entire group seemed to agree with that statement, all of them giving compliments of their own.

Glimmer couldn't help but turn her attention back to Catra, her smile the embodiment of smugness. "Try and top that, Horde Scum."

"Wow. Bringing back the pet name from our college days, are we now? You must really want to beat me."

"More like put you in your place. We all know that Adora was the one who did all the work."

"Actually," Adora interjected as she began to pass out her and Catra's card, "Catra took the reins on this one. She's worked really hard on it."

"Seriously?"

"Of course I did, Sparkles. Believe me when I tell you I've put my literal blood, sweat, and tears into this card."

"Your blood, sweat, and tears? Why are you always so dramatic!?"

Catra gestured towards the red envelope in the other's hand. "Take a quick peek at that, and you'll see what I mean."

With a huff, Glimmer practically ripped the object in half and pulled out the card. Upon examining the image printed onto it, her facial expression quickly shifted from annoyance to confusion, until finally, one of realization. "You can't be serious."

Catra smiled slyly. "Surprise!"

Adora and Catra were wearing tacky seasonal sweaters in the photograph, just like they always did. Horribly red ones too, with gaudy gold bows on them. What was different, however, was Adora beaming in the camera's direction as she held up a miniature version of the sweater. Proudly standing beside her,

Catra held up a small sign that read, 'The more the merrier! Baby Grayskull coming next summer.'

When everyone flipped the card over, they saw a sonogram and the words, 'twelve weeks on December 15th.'

Bow gasped, the joy on his face evident. "You're having a baby?!? I'm going to be an uncle!?"

"I'm going to be a mom!" Adora announced in reply, eagerly rushing over to the man and excitedly jumping up and down alongside him.

Next to them, Glimmer watched everyone around her coo at the couple's card. Just taking one quick look at Catra showed her that this reaction had been entirely expected.

They both knew what it meant.

Adora and Catra were winning this competition, no doubt about it. People absolutely loved pregnancy announcements, especially when it was the first one of the group. Glimmer and Bow's card could've been made out of pure gold, and it still wouldn't have bested theirs.

"I'll get you next year," Glimmer threatened. "Just watch."

Catra snorted, seemingly amused. "I've got two words for you, Sparkles; baby pictures."

Glimmer growled. People went nuts for those too.

Including her. "Well…I better at least get advanced copies of them!"

Catra nonchalantly waved her hand. "Sure."

"I'll be their favorite aunt too!" she quickly added. "Not Scorpia!"

“Of course you will.” This time, there was a softer tone in Catra’s response, her smile warm as she gently placed a hand on her stomach.

It was at that moment that it fully hit Glimmer; her best friends were having a baby, and she was going to be an aunt. Suddenly, losing the card contest was the farthest thing from her mind. “Congratulations, Horde Scum. On everything.”

“Thanks, Sparkles. Happy Solstice.”

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I haven't been doing a ton of writing lately, so this was really fun to do (and trying to stay within the zine's word limit was a fun challenge)

I highly encourage y'all to look at the zine itself and view the other fan works that were made from it; it's a really special collection that I'm so happy to have been a part of.

Link to Zine:

https://spopzines.itch.io/spopflexicebreakerzine

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!